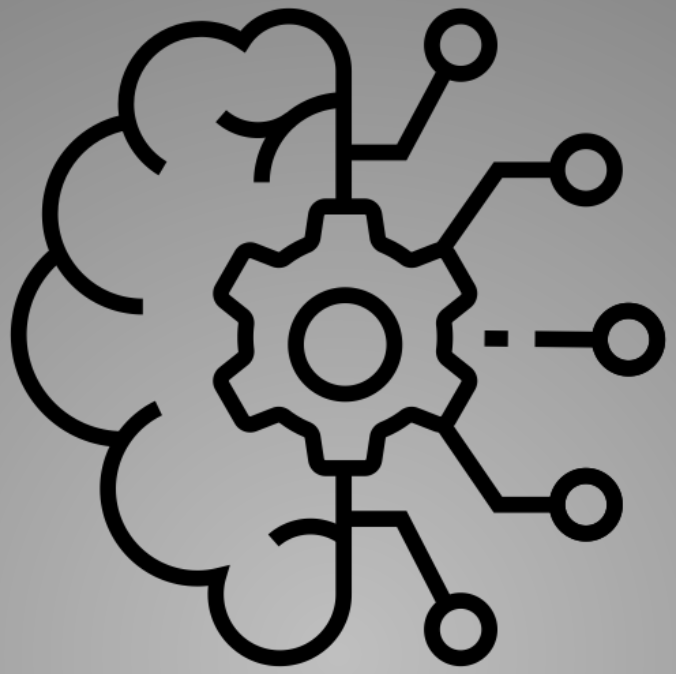
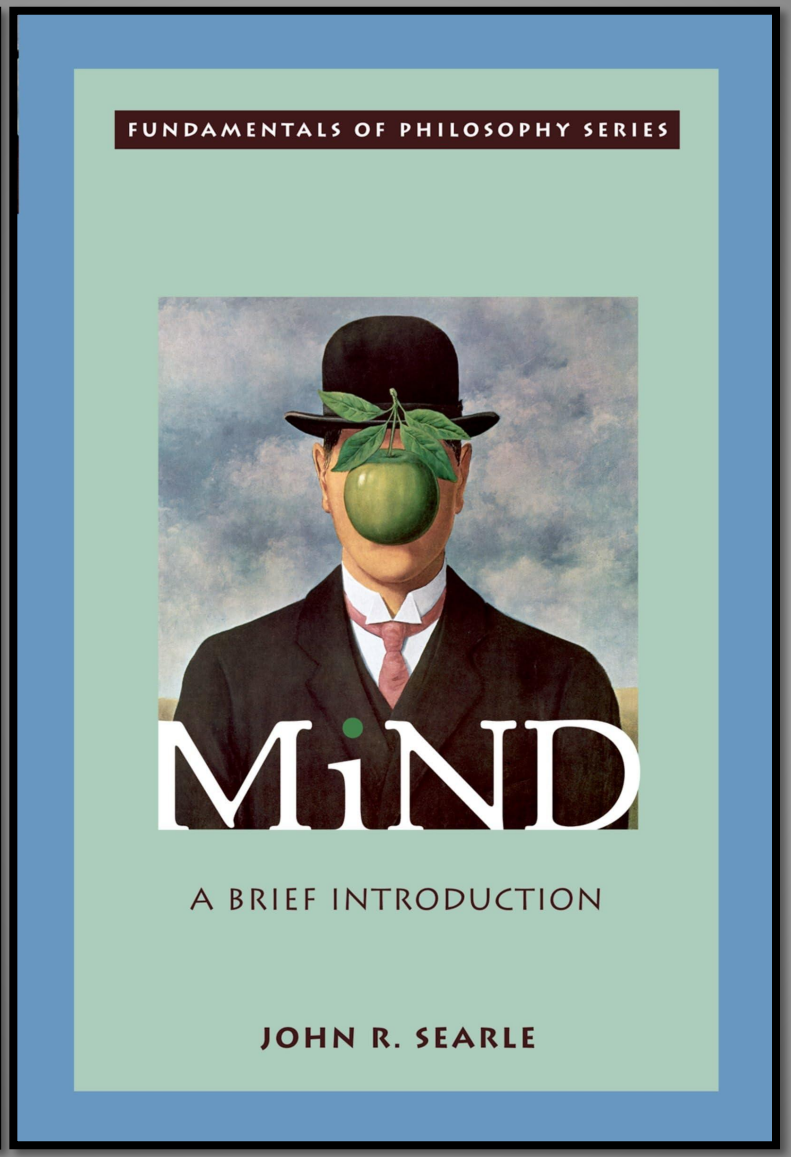
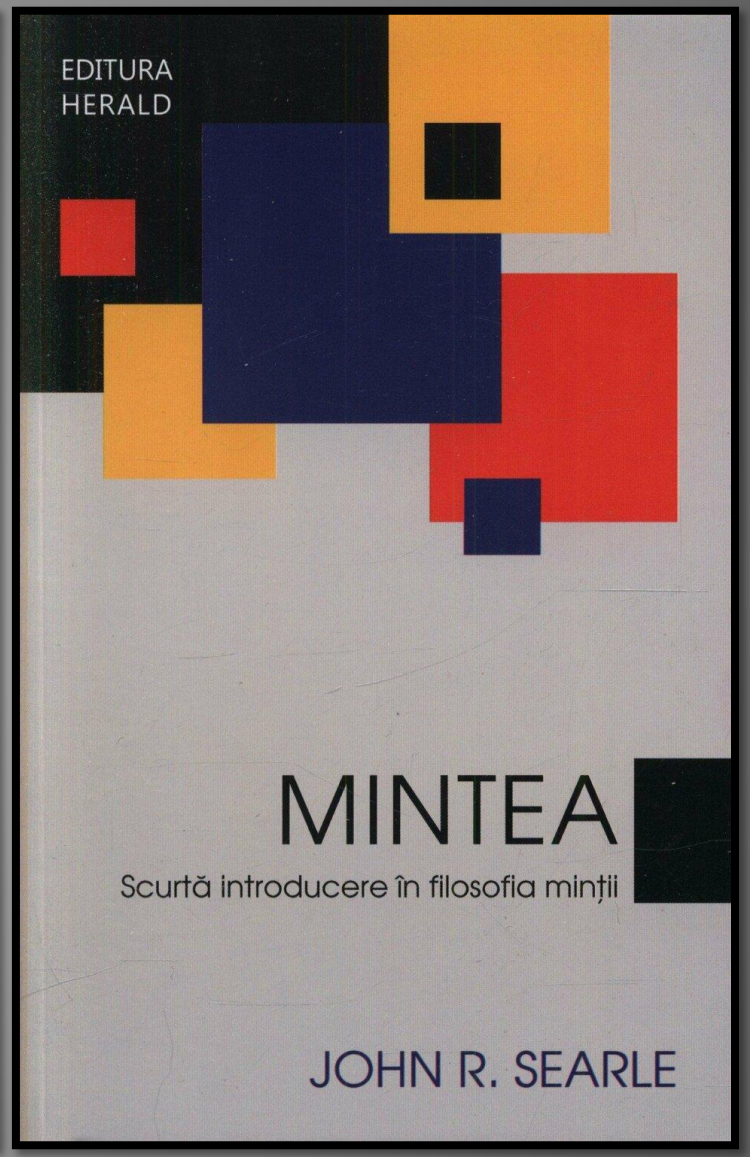


PHILOSOPHY OF MIND

Philosophy of mind is the branch of philosophy that studies the nature of the mind, mental states, consciousness, and their relationship to the body—especially the brain—and to the physical world.


FUNDAMENTALS OF PHILOSOPHY SERIES
MiND
A BRIEF INTRODUCTION
JOHN R. SEARLE


EDITURA
HERALD
MINTEA
Scurtă introducere în filosofia minții
JOHN R. SEARLE

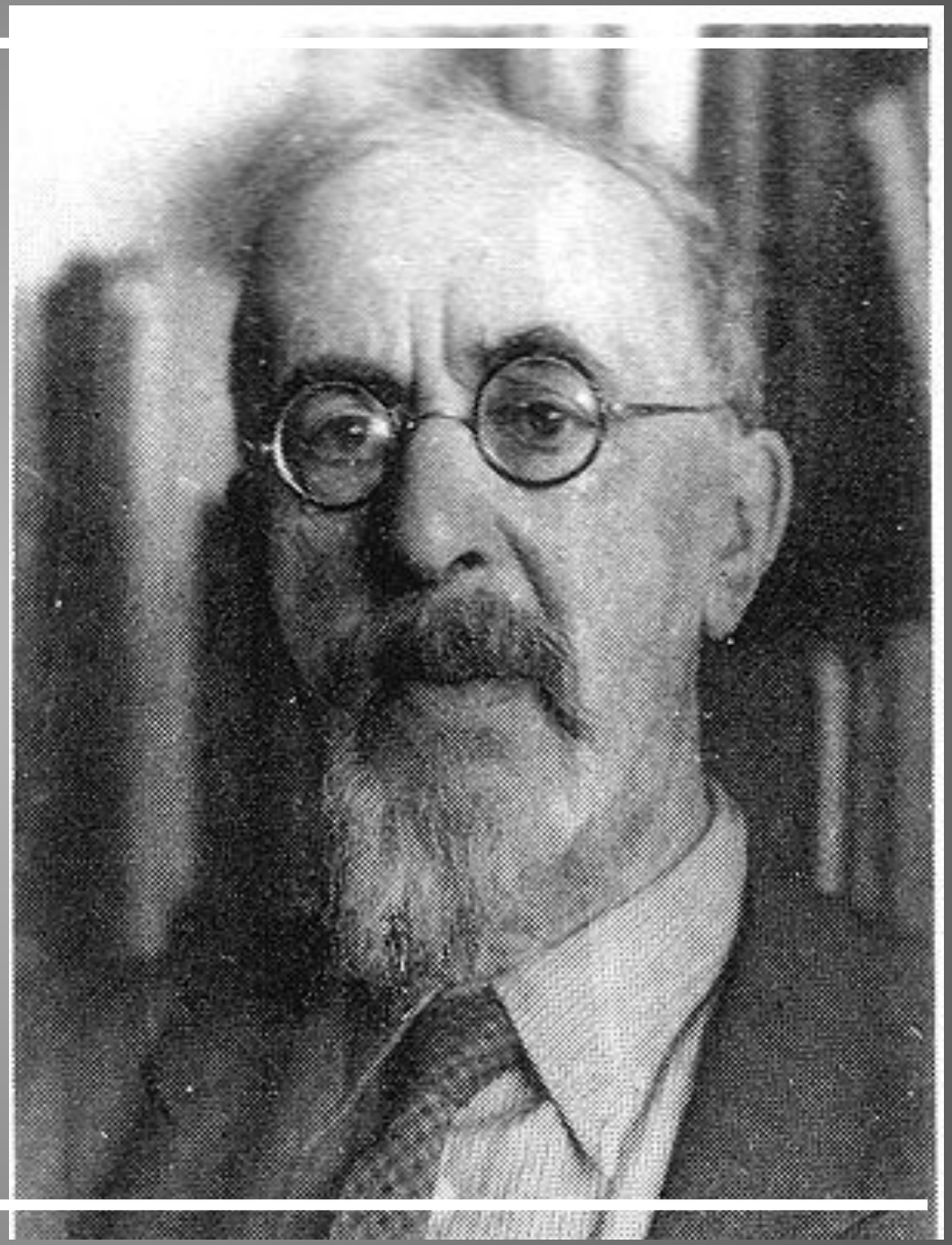
KEY IDEAS:

Biological Naturalism: Searle argues that consciousness is a real, biological phenomenon caused by processes in the brain. It is both irreducible to physical states and fully anchored in the physical world, thus avoiding dualism and reductionism.

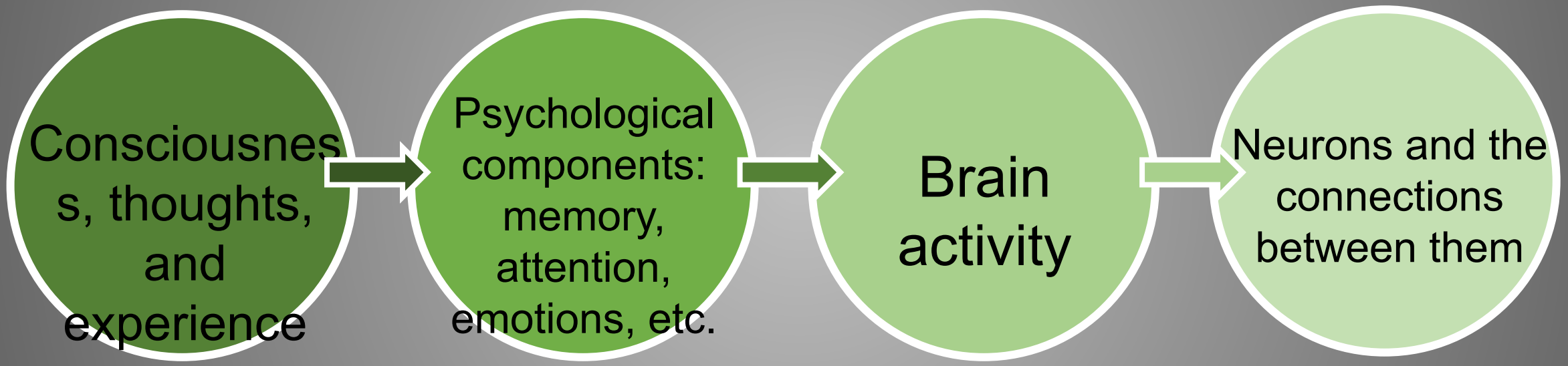
Reductionism

- Methodological
- Epistemological
- Ontological

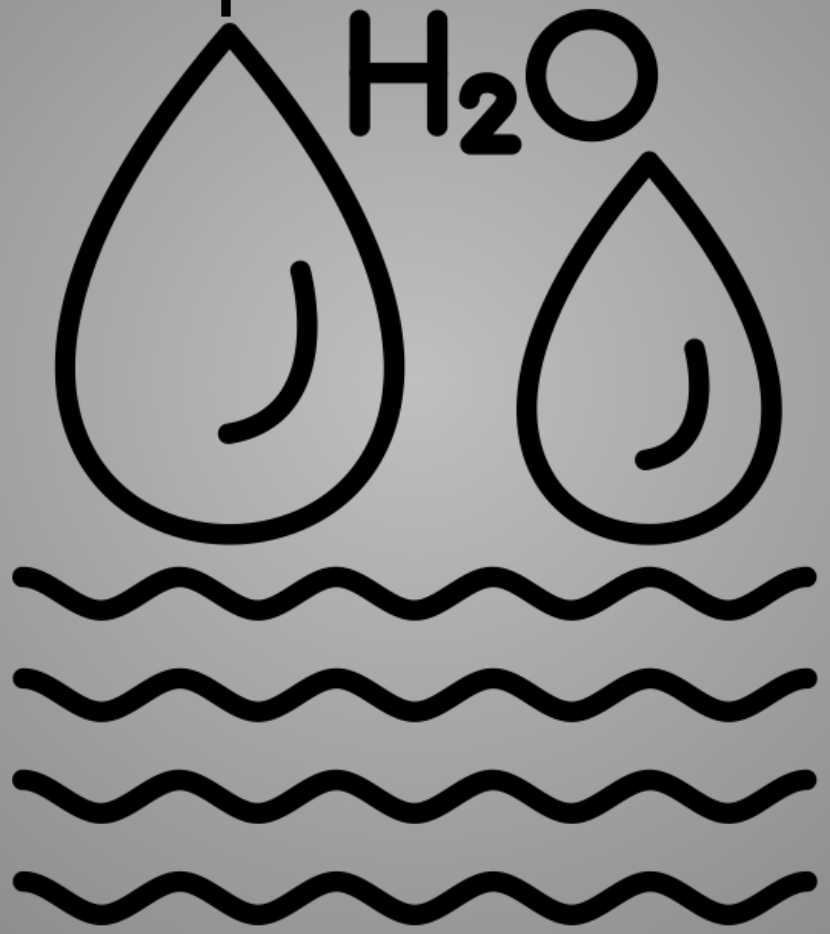
"The discussion between a believer and a non-believer is basically as useless as one between someone who understands music and someone who has no ear for music. If someone tells me that Beethoven's Ninth Symphony is just a mix of sounds reaching the ear as waves, I can answer: yes, that's true, but at the same time, it is something much



"The whole is more than the sum of its parts."



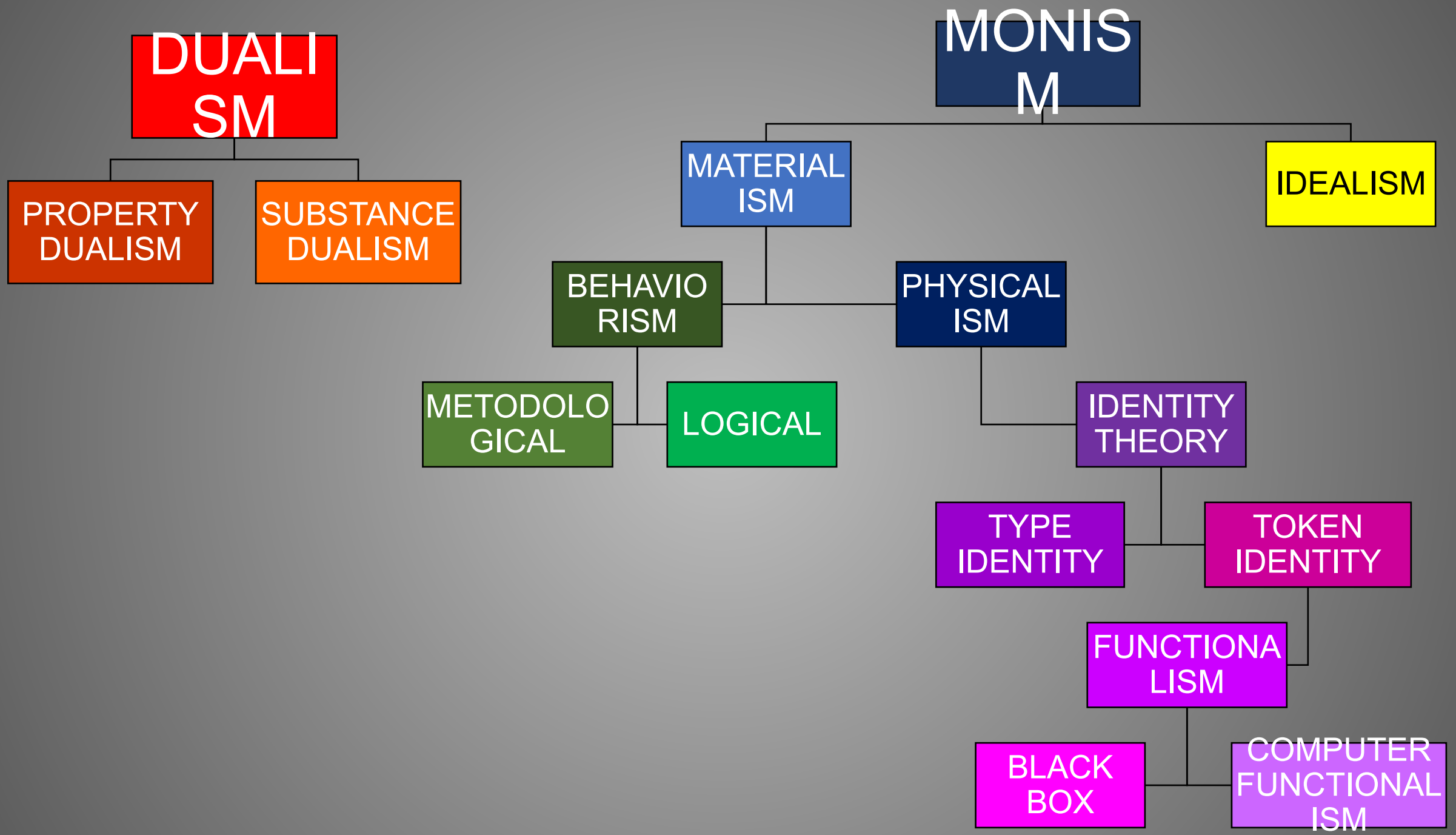
Emergent Properties



KEY IDEAS:

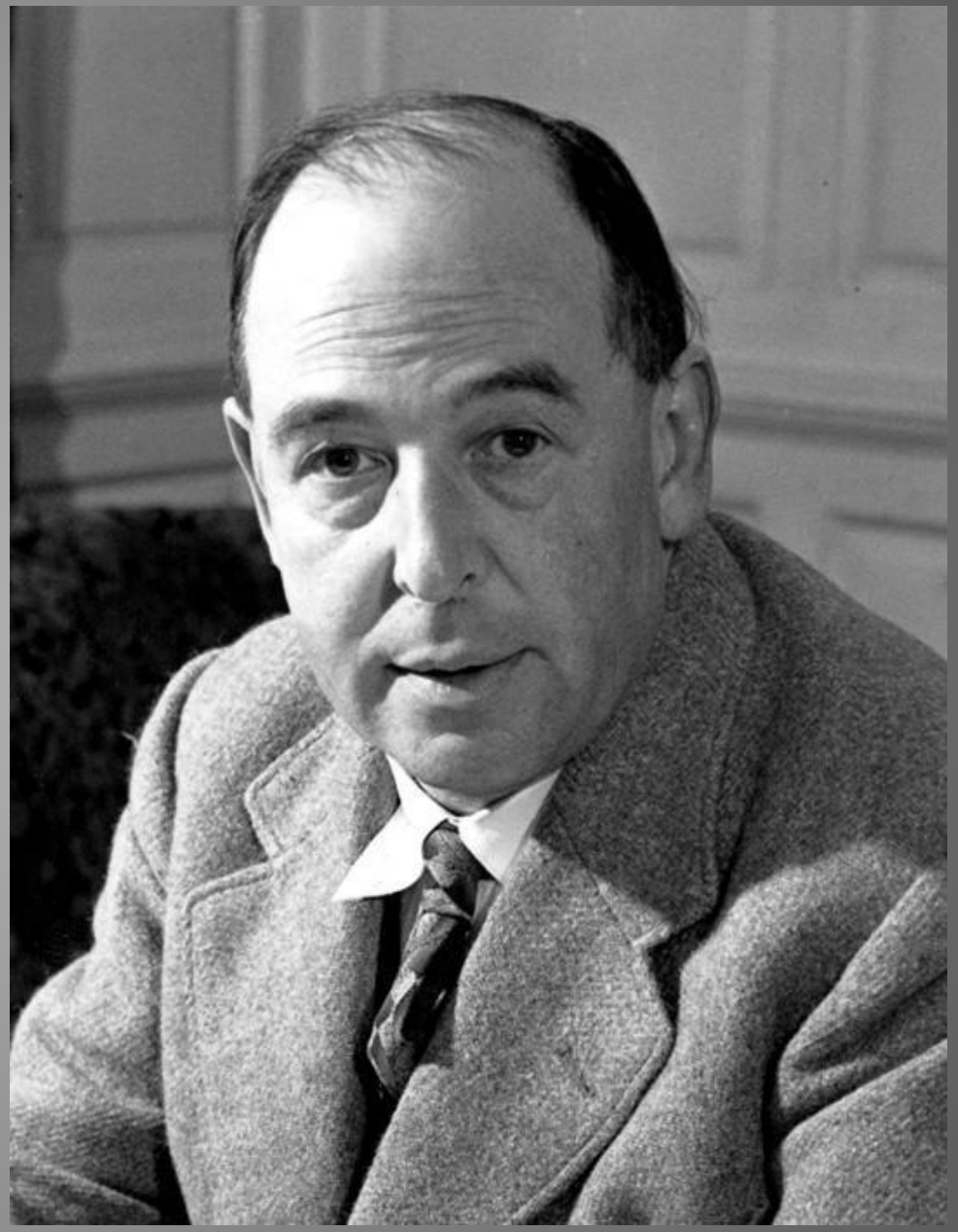
Critique of Dualism and Materialism: Searle rejects Cartesian dualism (the separation of mind and body) as untenable. Similarly, he criticizes materialist views like behaviorism, functionalism, and eliminative materialism for failing to account for the subjective, qualitative nature of consciousness (the "first-person perspective").

“(…) philosophy of mind is unique among contemporary philosophical subjects, in that all of the most famous and influential theories are false. By such theories I mean just about anything that has 'ism' in its name. I am thinking of dualism, both property dualism and substance dualism, materialism, physicalism, computationalism, functionalism, behaviorism, epiphenomenalism, cognitivism, eliminativism, panpsychism, dual-aspect theory, and


DUALISM
PROPERTY DUALISM
SUBSTANCE DUALISM
MONISM
MATERIALISM
IDEALISM
BEHAVIORISM
PHYSICALISM
METODOLOGICAL
LOGICAL
IDENTITY THEORY
TYPE IDENTITY
TOKEN IDENTITY
FUNCTIONALISM
BLACK BOX
COMPUTER FUNCTIONALISM

The “Argument from Reason”

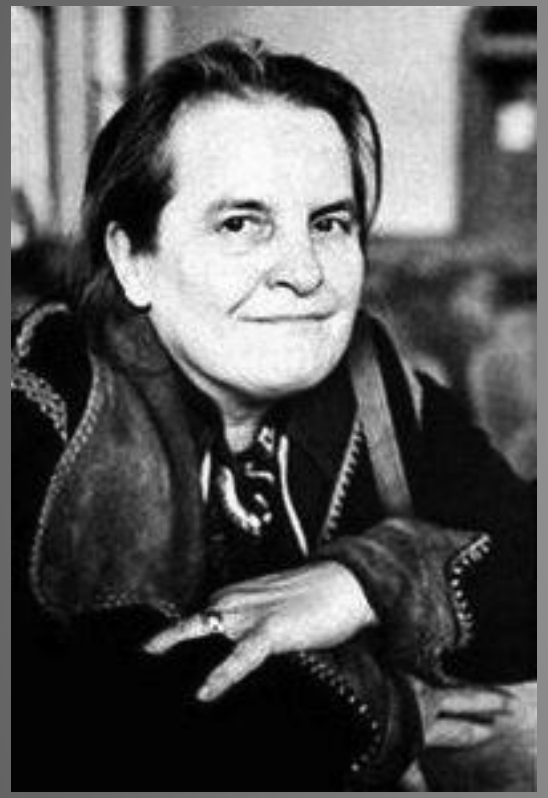
"If minds are wholly dependent on brains, and brains on biochemistry, and biochemistry (in the long run) on the meaningless flux of the atoms, I cannot understand how the thought of those minds should have any more significance than the sound of the wind in the trees." — C.S. Lewis



The Logic Chain:

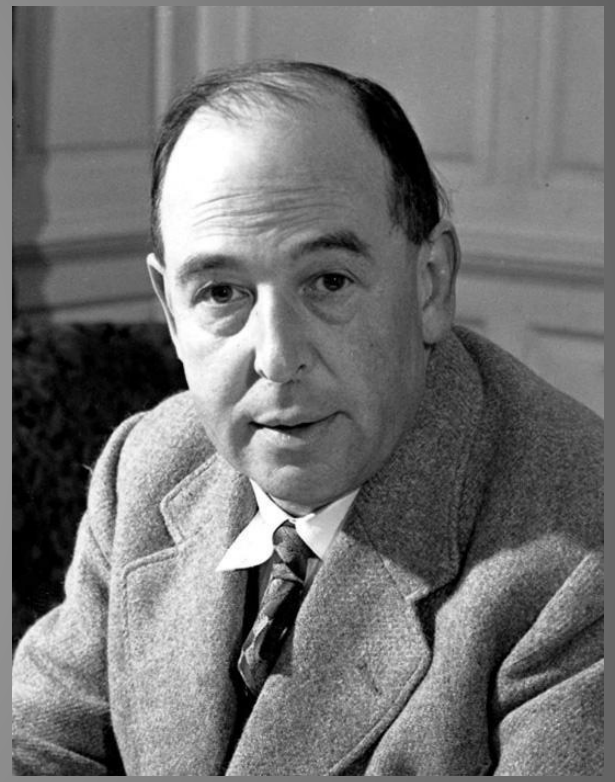
1. If Naturalism is true, all thoughts are the result of irrational physical causes.
2. If a thought is the result of an irrational cause, it is not a valid rational insight.
3. Therefore, if Naturalism is true, we have no reason to trust our reasoning.
4. This includes the reasoning used to accept Naturalism

The Criticism and the Rewrite (Lewis vs. Anscombe)



This part of history is fascinating because it shows how a great thinker improves his ideas when challenged.

In 1948, C.S. Lewis had a famous debate with Elizabeth Anscombe, a brilliant young philosopher. Her criticism was so precise that Lewis decided to completely rewrite Chapter 3 of his book *Miracles*.



Anscombe’s Criticism: Physical causes aren't "bad“

In the first version of the book, Lewis argued that if thoughts have natural (physical) causes, they are irrational and cannot be trusted.

Anscombe argued that Physical Causes (brain atoms) and Logical Reasons (truth) can exist at the same time.

Anscombe corrected him on two main points:

- "Irrational" vs. "Non-rational": She said Lewis was mixing up words. A physical cause (like a fever or alcohol) can create *irrational* thoughts (delusions). But a normal physical cause (a healthy brain working properly) is just non-rational (it’s not true or false, it just *is*). Just because a thought comes from a physical brain doesn't automatically mean it is false.

- Logic vs. Physics: She argued that logic applies to *arguments*, while physics applies to *brain events*. You can have a physical machine (like a calculator) that produces logical answers without actually "thinking."

Lewis’s Response: The New Argument

Lewis accepted the criticism. In the revised edition (1960), he refined his argument:

- He stopped saying that physical causes make thoughts "false.“
- The New Problem: The new argument focuses on Justification. He argued that if Naturalism is true, we have no guarantee that our thoughts are reliable.
- The "Insight": Lewis focused on the act of "seeing" the truth. Even if a computer gives the right answer, it doesn't "know" the truth. For humans to have knowledge, our minds must be guided by logic, not just by biology.

The "Because" Analogy

- To explain this clearly, Lewis uses the two different meanings of the word "Because.“
- If Naturalism is true, it confuses these two meanings.

"Because" = Cause and Effect (Physical)

This describes a physical chain of events.

- *Example:* "Grandfather is sick because he ate bad seafood.“
- *What is happening:* The seafood physically caused a chemical reaction in his stomach. This is a blind, biological process.

"Because" = Evidence/Reason (Logical)

This describes a logical conclusion or a clue.

- *Example:* "Grandfather must be sick because he hasn't gotten out of bed yet.“

- *What is happening:* Him staying in bed is not the *cause* of his illness (staying in bed didn't make him sick). Him staying in bed is the reason I believe he is sick. It is a logical deduction.

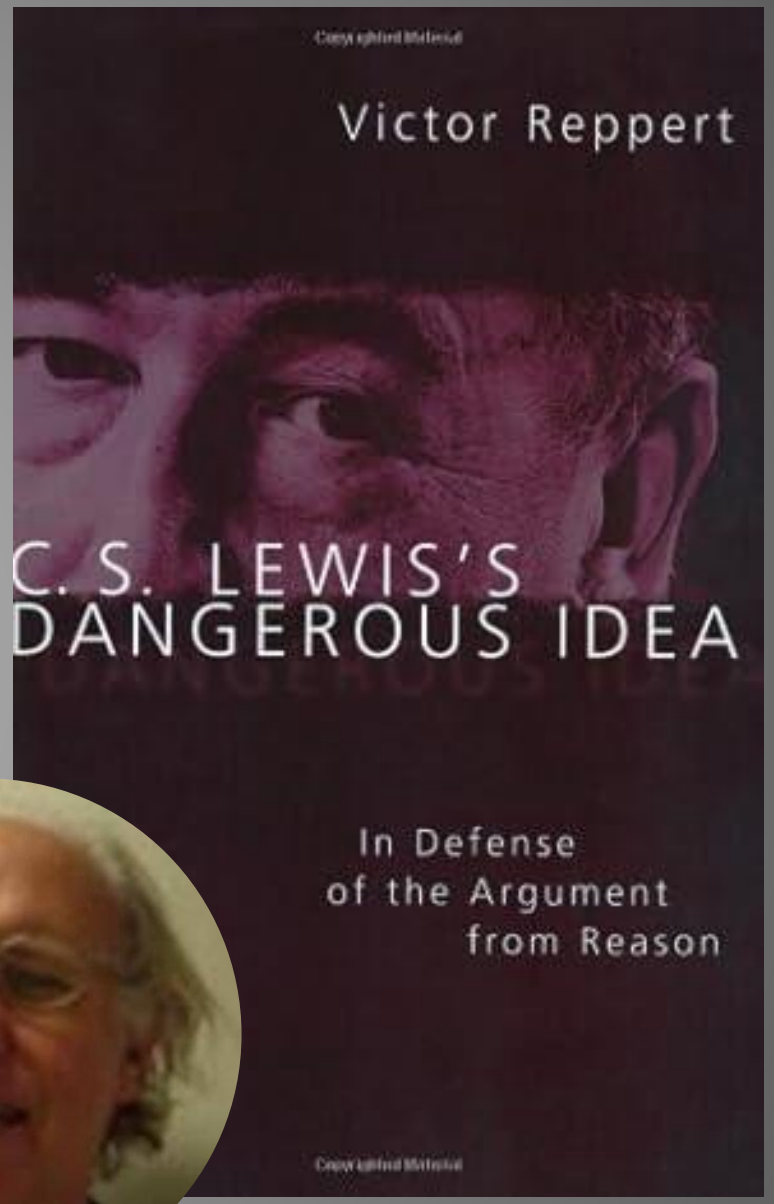
The "Act of Seeing“

Lewis argues that real thinking requires an "Aha!" moment.

- You have to "see" that a conclusion follows from the evidence (Type 2).
- The Problem: If Naturalism is true, your thoughts are just physical events (Type 1: like the seafood reacting in the stomach). One thought leads to another just because neurons bumped into each other.
- The Conclusion: If your belief that "Naturalism is true" is caused only by brain chemistry (Type 1), then you never really "saw" the logic (Type 2). You were just forced by physics to think that. Therefore, if Naturalism is true, you can't trust your own mind.

Victor Reppert is a contemporary philosopher who took C.S. Lewis's argument, cleaned it up, and modernized it to answer critics like Anscombe.

While Lewis presented one big "Argument from Reason," Reppert breaks it down into six specific problems that Naturalism (Materialism) cannot solve. He calls these the



The Core Idea

Reppert argues that for us to accept Naturalism (the idea that only the physical world exists), we have to use Reason. But if Naturalism is true, Reason shouldn't exist. Therefore, Naturalism kills itself.

He breaks this down into specific "impossible tasks" for a purely physical brain.

1. The Argument from Intentionality (The "Aboutness" Problem)

The Problem: Physical objects are not "about" anything. A rock is just a rock. A group of atoms is just a group of atoms.

- **Reppert's Point:** Your thoughts are about something (e.g., you are thinking *about* Paris).
- **The Question:** How can a clump of neurons (matter) be "about" a city in France? Matter just exists; it doesn't "mean" anything. If Naturalism is true, "meaning" shouldn't exist.

2. The Argument from Truth

The Problem: In the physical world, things just exist. They aren't "true" or "false."

- **Example:** A chemical reaction in a test tube isn't "true." It just happens.
- **Reppert's Point:** If thoughts are just chemical reactions in the brain, they can't be true or false either. They are just biological events. But reasoning requires us to have true thoughts.

3. The Argument from Mental Causation (The "Driver" Problem)

This is Reppert's strongest update to Lewis's "Because" argument.

- **Scenario:** You calculate that 2$ + 2$ = 4$.
- **Logical Cause:** You think "4" because of the logic of the numbers (the content).
- **Physical Cause:** You think "4" because Neuron A fired and hit Neuron B (the physics).

4. The Argument from the Psychological Relevance of Logical Laws

This is subtle but important. It asks: How do abstract laws of logic actually "touch" a physical brain?

- **The Problem:** Laws of physics (gravity, electromagnetism) clearly affect matter. But "Laws of Logic" (like *Law of Non-Contradiction*) are abstract ideas. They are not physical forces.

- **Reppert's Point:** For us to reason, the Laws of Logic must somehow "guide" the movement of particles in our brain.

- **The Conflict:** If Naturalism is true, the only laws moving the atoms in your brain are the laws of physics. Logic is just a spectator. If logic doesn't actually *steer* the brain, then we aren't being rational; we are just being physical.

5. The Argument from the Unity of Consciousness

This argues that a machine made of parts cannot "infer" a conclusion.

- **The Scenario:** To think logically, you need to combine two ideas to get a third.
  - Premise A: "All men are mortal."
  - Premise B: "Socrates is a man."
  - Conclusion: "Therefore, Socrates is mortal.“

- **The Problem:** If the brain is just a collection of billions of separate neurons:
  - One part of the brain holds "Premise A."
  - Another part holds "Premise B."
  - **Who connects them?**

- **Reppert’s Point:** For reasoning to happen, there must be a single, unified "Self" (an "I") that holds both premises *at the same time* and sees

6. The Argument from the Reliability of our Rational Faculties

This overlaps with Alvin Plantinga’s famous evolutionary argument.

- **The Problem:** If Naturalism and Evolution are true, our brains were shaped by natural selection solely for survival (feeding, fighting, fleeing, reproducing).

- **Reppert’s Point:** Evolution doesn't care about "Truth" (especially abstract philosophical truth); it cares about "Usefulness."
  - *Example:* If believing that "a tiger is a demon" makes you run away faster, evolution will select that belief, even if it is false.

- **The Conflict:** If our brains were built only for survival, not for truth, why should we trust them when they do complex philosophy or physics? We have no reason to believe our "survival machine" is good at finding deep truths about the universe.

SEARLE'S KEY IDEAS:

Consciousness and Subjectivity: Consciousness, for Searle, is inherently subjective and qualitative. He challenges views that try to explain consciousness solely in terms of computational or purely physical processes.

Qualia (singular: *quale*) are the *subjective, first-person qualities* of conscious experience—the "what it feels like" aspect of mental states.

Examples:

- the redness *as it appears* to you when you see a red apple,
- the bitterness *as it tastes* to you in a cup of coffee,
- the pain *as it feels* to you when you touch something hot.

In philosophy of mind, *qualia* refer to these inner, phenomenal, experiential properties that seem accessible

NYU
MANHATTAN
BROOKLYN
25 YEARS OF

KEY IDEAS:

The Chinese Room Argument: Searle reintroduces his famous thought experiment as a critique of strong AI, which claims that computers can truly understand and exhibit consciousness. He argues that understanding requires more than symbol manipulation—it necessitates genuine semantic content, which machines lack.

In
你好
我喜欢阅读
Out

KEY IDEAS:

Free Will: Searle addresses the problem of free will, arguing that our sense of agency, though seemingly at odds with determinism, is fundamental to understanding human experience.

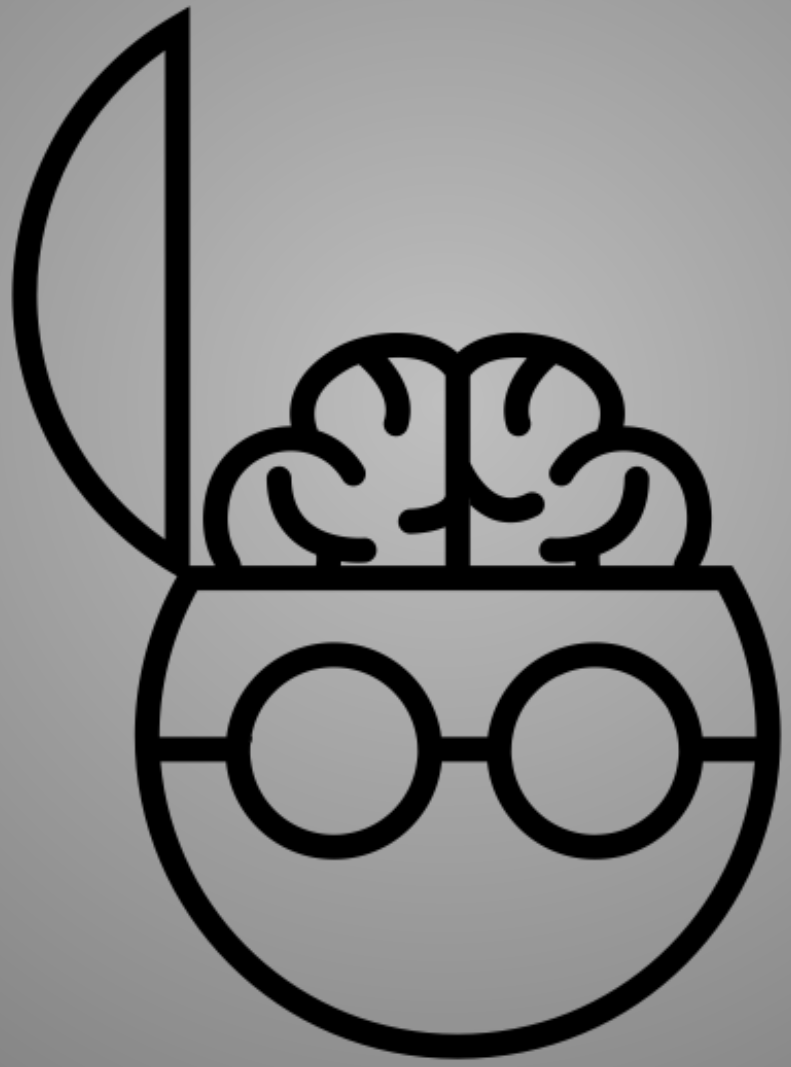
CARTESIAN DUALISM

	Substances	
	Mind	**Body**
Essence	Thinking (consciousness)	Extension (having spatial dimensions)
Properties	Known directly Free Indivisible Indestructible	Known indirectly Determined Infinitely divisible Destructible

A Dozen Problems in the Philosophy of Mind

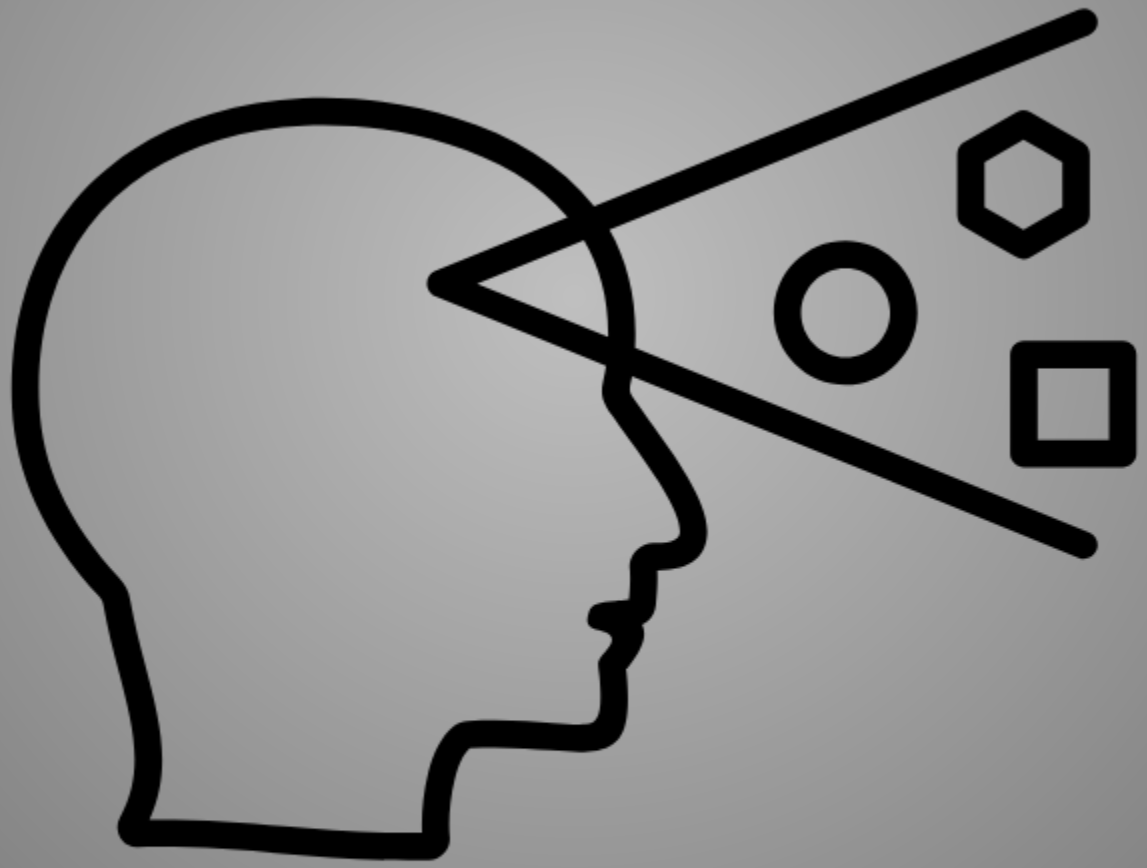
1. The Mind-Body Problem

2. The Problem of Other Minds

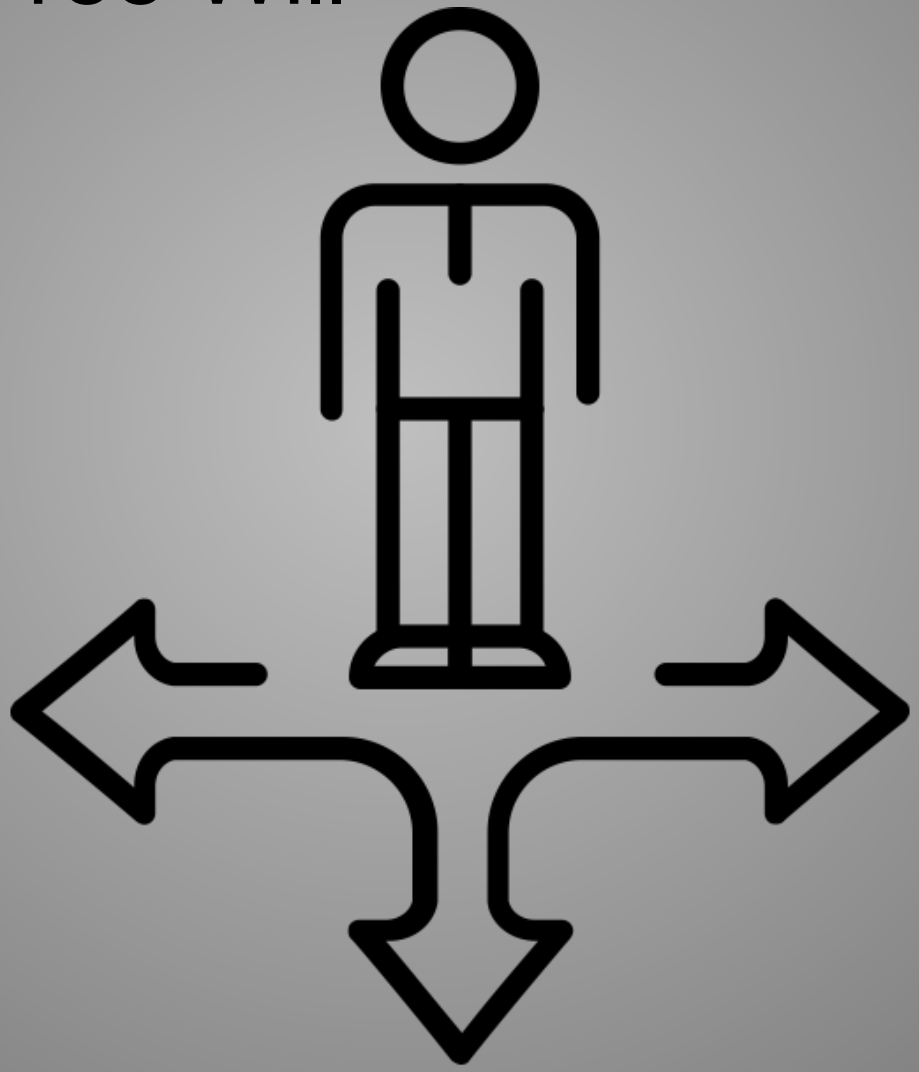


3. The Problem of Skepticism about the External World

4. The Analysis of Perception

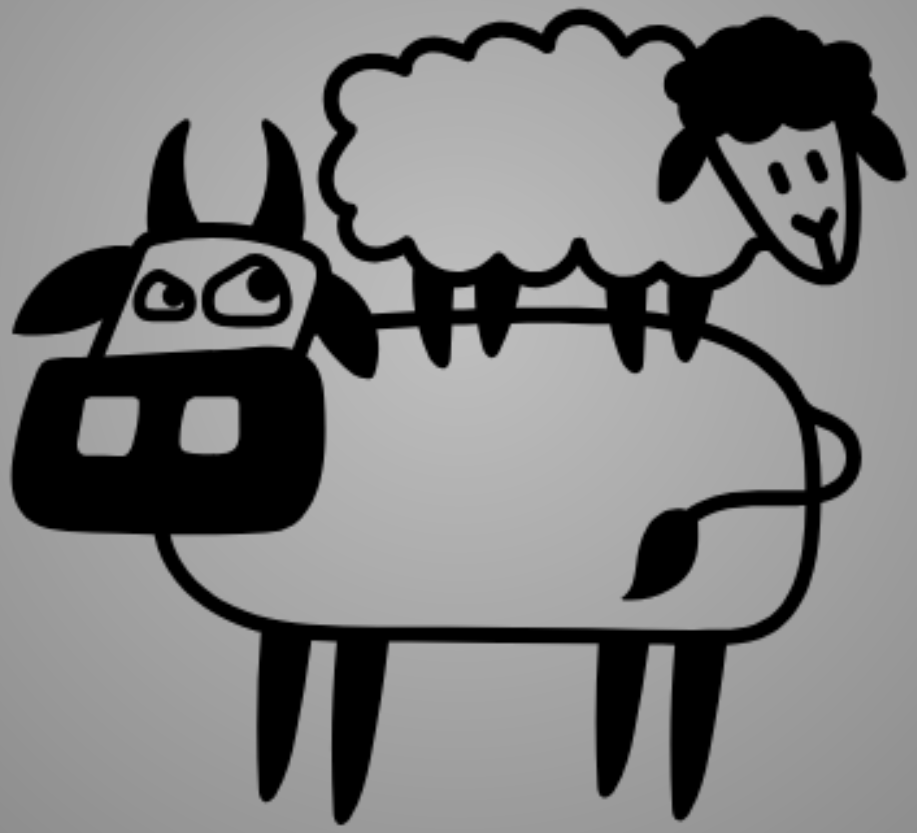


5. The Problem of Free Will



6. The Self and Personal Identity

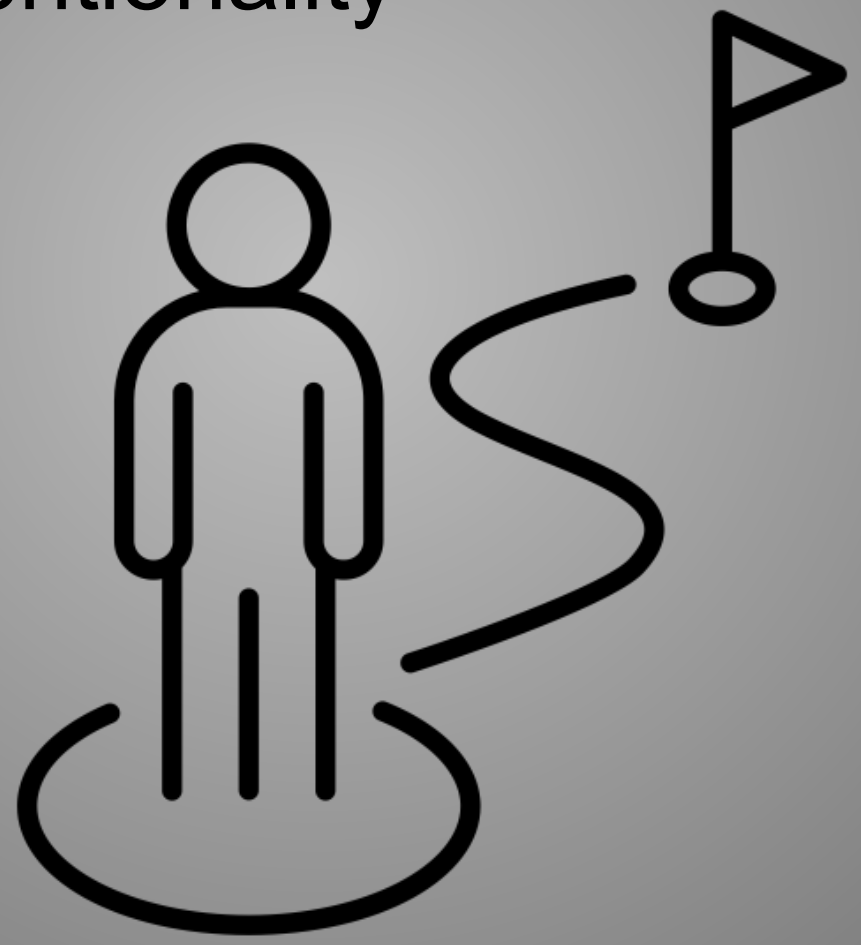
7. Do Animals Have Minds?



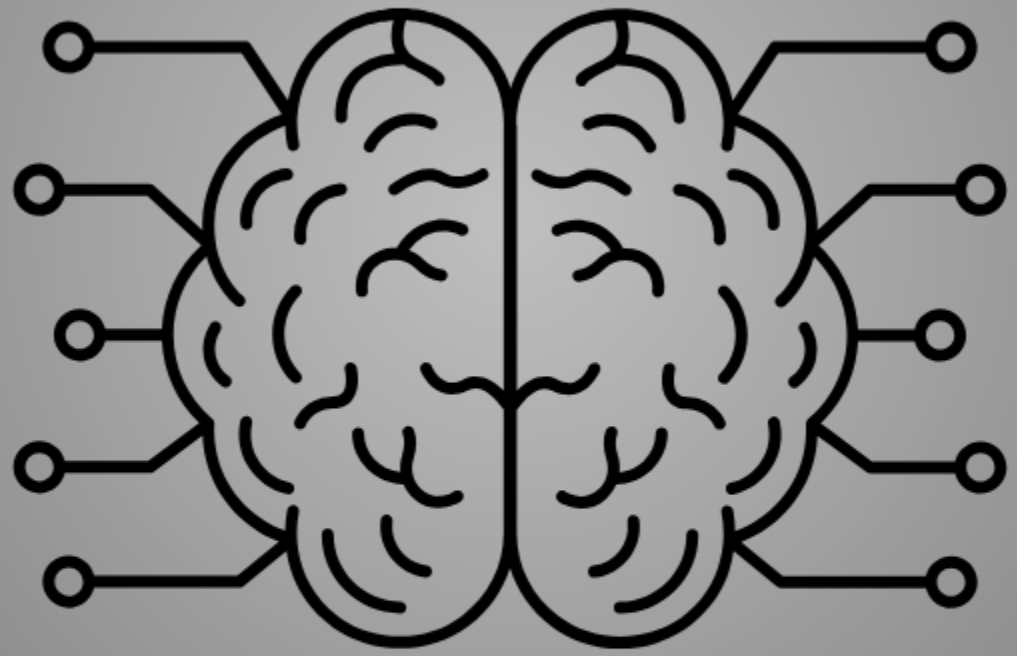
8. The Problem of Sleep

FOUR MORE PROBLEMS

9. The Problem of Intentionality



10. Mental Causation and Epiphenomenalism



11. The Unconscious

12. Psychological and Social Explanation

"Among the worst things we can do is to give readers the impression that they understand something they do not really understand, that something has been explained when it has not been explained, and that a problem has been solved when it has not been solved.“